

Close Reading 1: Hassan and Amir

After Amir asks if Hassan would “eat dirt if I told you to”, there is a description of Hassan’s face: “His eyes searched my face for a long time. We sat there, two boys under a sour cherry tree, suddenly looking, *really* looking, at each other. That’s when it happened again: Hassan’s face changed. Maybe not *changed*, not really, but suddenly I had the feeling I was looking at two faces, the one I knew, the one that was my first memory, and another, a second face, this one lurking just beneath the surface. I’d seen it happen before — it always shook me up a little. It just appeared, this other face, for a fraction of a moment, long enough to leave me with the unsettling feeling that maybe I’d seen it someplace before. Then Hassan blinked and it was just him again. Just Hassan.” (54)

1. What do you think this “second face” looks like?
2. Notice that the narrator only knows one of his faces, and the “second face” unsettles him. Why do you think Hassan has a “second face”? What does this suggest about Hassan’s identity?
3. How does this “second face” complicate the reading that Hassan is straightforwardly devoted to the narrator?
4. Do you think the narrator knows who Hassan is? When the narrator says “Hassan blinked and it was just him again”, is this the real Hassan, or the false Hassan?

The scene continues:

“If you asked, I would,” he finally said, looking right at me. I dropped my eyes. To this day, I find it hard to gaze directly at people like Hassan, people who mean every word they say.

“But I wonder,” he added. “Would you ever ask me to do such a thing, Amir agha?” And, just like that, he had thrown at me his own little test. If I was going to toy with him and challenge his loyalty, then he’d toy with me, test my integrity.

I wished I hadn’t started this conversation. I forced a smile. “Don’t be stupid, Hassan. You know I wouldn’t.”

Hassan returned the smile. Except his didn’t look forced. “I know,” he said. And that’s the thing about people who mean everything they say. They think everyone else does too. (55)

1. What does it mean to mean everything you say? What would it mean to *not* mean everything you say? Is lying the same as not meaning everything you say?
2. The text suggests that the narrator did not mean what he said when he says “Don’t be stupid, Hassan. You know I wouldn’t.” Why do you think this is the case?
3. Do you think it’s true that “people who mean everything they say” “think everyone else does too”, or is this the narrator’s prejudice?

Close Reading 2: Baba

“Then I saw Baba on our roof. He was standing on the edge, pumping both of his fists. Hollering and clapping. And that right there was the single greatest moment of my twelve years of life, seeing Baba on the roof, proud of me at last.

But he was doing something now, motioning with his hands in an urgent way. Then I understood.” (66)

1. Why is Baba motioning with his hands? What happens as a consequence?
2. After hollering and clapping, proud of Amir, Baba immediately motions for him to do something else. Baba can’t sit still with pride. What does this show about the nature of his pride for his son?

Close Reading 3: The Lamb and the Blood

Examine the symbolism of “the lamb” in page 76, beginning with “It was the look of the lamb” and ending with the italicized part. The lamb is a religious symbol; Jesus is often called “the lamb of the world”, and all Abrahamic religions (Judaism, Christianity, Islam) share the story of the Binding of Isaac, in which Abraham takes his only son Isaac up into the mountains and obeys God’s command to kill him. At the last moment, an angel intervenes, stopping Abraham from killing Isaac, and Abraham kills a sacrificial lamb instead.

1. How is this story relevant to what is happening to Hassan?
2. How is it not relevant?
3. Do you think the story is resonant with Hassan's "sacrifice", or is it another way for the narrator to justify and rationalize what is happening?

Examine how the symbolism of the lamb continues with the imagery of blood. In pages 92-93, the narrator pelts Hassan with pomegranates. Hassan eventually hits his own face with a pomegranate, "red dripping down his face like blood." In page 94, the poplar tree where Hassan and the narrator played on as children is sprayed with the blood of literal sheep, with the butcher saying "blood is good for the tree", and "the grass around the poplar soaked red."

1. What does the pomegranate tree and the poplar tree symbolize?
2. Examine how the symbolism of the biblical lamb, the pomegranate, and the literal sheep's blood interact. Notice that Hassan hit his *own* face with the pomegranate. What does this show about Hassan?
3. What would have happened if Hassan pelted the narrator back with pomegranates? Do you think they could have made up and talked to each other again?

Close Reading 4: The Narrator's Decision

"I had one last chance to make a decision. One final opportunity to decide who I was going to be. I could step into that alley, stand up for Hassan — the way he'd stood up for me all those times in the past — and accept whatever would happen to me. Or I would run.

In the end, I ran.

I ran because I was a coward. I was afraid of Assef and what he would do to me. I was afraid of getting hurt. That's what I told myself as I turned my back to the alley, to Hassan. That's what I made myself believe. I actually *aspired* to cowardice, because the alternative, the real reason I was running, was that Assef was right: Nothing was free in this world. Maybe Hassan was the price I had to pay, the lamb I had to slay, to win Baba. Was it a fair price? The answer floated to my conscious mind before I could thwart it: He was just a Hazara, wasn't he?" (77)

1. One might wonder why Hassan doesn't do the obvious thing — he could run for help from a trusted adult. For example, he could ask Baba for help. Why do you think he doesn't do that?
2. What do you think would have happened if he asked Baba for help?
3. Later in the book, Baba stands up to the attempted rape of a woman. Do you think part of why the narrator is unable to tell about the rape is because Hassan is a boy? How do you think the situation would have been different if Hassan were a girl? Do you think it doesn't matter and Baba would have stood up for Hassan regardless of his gender?
4. What do you think would have happened if he asked Rahim Khan for help?
5. The narrator says he had "one final opportunity to decide who I was going to be" — which is to "stand up for Hassan." This echoes the dialogue he overheard his father have with Rahim Khan, in which his father says "A boy who won't stand up for himself becomes a man who can't stand up to anything." How does this dialogue he overheard become a curse for the narrator?
6. How might the fact that it is same-sex rape make it difficult for the narrator and Hassan to talk about what happened?

Close Reading 5: The Confession

Context: the narrator goes on a trip to Jalalabad with his extended family. At night, lying together with his relatives, he cannot sleep, thinking about Hassan.

"A wedge of moonlight streamed in through the window.

"I watched Hassan get raped," I said to no one. Baba stirred in his sleep. Kaka Homayoun grunted. A part of me was hoping someone would wake up and hear, so I wouldn't have to live with this lie anymore. But no one woke up and in the silence that followed, I understood the nature of my new curse: I was going to get away with it." (86)

1. The narrator wishes someone would wake up and hear. Why doesn't he say it more loudly?
2. The line, "I understood the nature of my new curse: I was going to get away with it." is very complex. What is the narrator "going to get away with"?

3. This is a kind of guilt that, just because you are not going to be held on trial for the guilt, you feel more guilty about. Have you ever felt this way?
4. Is it right for the narrator to feel guilty in the first place? Why is he the one feeling the guilt, when the person who ought to be guilty and punished is, obviously, Assef?

Character Analysis: Assef

Assef is described as admiring Hitler, as racist against Hazaras, and he rapes Hassan. What kind of character is Assef? Is Assef evil incarnate or is there anything sympathetic about him? Examine pages 95-97 for Assef's friendly conversation with Baba. If Assef is evil incarnate, how is he able to fool those around him as a model son? Examine the line about his eyes: "when I looked into them, the facade faltered, revealed a glimpse of the madness hiding behind him." (97) Compare this with the line about Hassan's "second face".